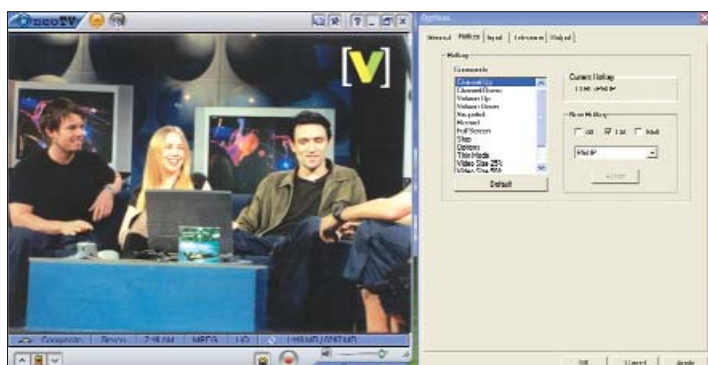




A user-customisable hotkey is available under NeoTV's configuration settings

you to set up audio/video sources and channels. You are taken to the 'Configuration Options' dialog box. After you're done with setting up the software, the rather ordinary blue user interface shows up. Moving the mouse pointer over the buttons reveals their functions. There aren't too many options on the panel for setting up the software, which makes NeoTV good for first-time users.

Features And Performance

A unique feature in NeoTV is the reconfigurable Hotkey option. User-defined keys can be set; this helps you easily remember the keys you set for various functions such as record, stop, next channel, previous channel, etc.

NeoTV can handle recording of telecasts in MPEG, VCD and DVD formats, and snapshots are saved as BMP files. The quality of snapshots is really good, but we couldn't judge the quality of video capture—the saved file turned out to be corrupt. Our repeated attempts to capture video in different formats were in vain. Given the fact that we weren't even able to capture video, we can't recommend NeoTV.

Link: www.mediostream.com/products/index_neotv.html

PowerVCR II 3.0

CyberLink's PowerVCR II is the most commonly bundled software with most TV-Tuner cards. With the advent of Media Center PCs, CyberLink now supplies PowerCinema. Nevertheless, PowerVCR II still has the punch to be amongst the most-sought-after PVR software.

Ease Of Use

The procedure for installing PowerVCR II 3.0 was somewhat lengthy—it installs the Intel Indeo codec pack right in the middle of installation. The option to not install Indeo wasn't offered.

Those who have used CyberLink products earlier will know the characteristic interface scheme—it resembles an actual DVD player with knobs and buttons. A similar scheme is used here, more like a blend of a set-top box and a DVD player. The preview screen looks like a flat plasma TV.

A side panel bar is provided to directly access certain features such as the recording scheduler and the DV Tape Transcoder. Overall, the interface and the software are elegantly and professionally designed.

The software starts with a hunt for channels and stops at the very first signal it detects; detection is so fast, you'll notice it only if you disconnect the TV cable and connect only the composite input. This is of immense help, because you don't have to dig around in the configuration settings to set an input mode for the software—the available signal is quickly detected.

Features And Performance

Despite the professional look of the software, PowerVCR seemed to be lacking on the features front. Its closest contender is WinDVR, which impressed us with its performance and features; read on to see whether PowerVCR can keep its winner tag from a couple of years ago.

The snapshot feature took images only in BMP format, and although the clarity of the images was commendable, it would have been nice to have an option for JPEG.

The 'Instant TV Replay' feature allows you to pause a live telecast while it (the ongoing telecast) is being recorded to disk. You can, therefore, replay and even forward ads at will. The file converter helps convert a captured file from MPEG to other formats such as AVI.



The interface of PowerVCR is very similar to that of PowerDVD. Most features are accessible on the panels

If you want to record everything on your camcorder to DVD, you can use the 'DV Tape Transcoder' feature, which converts your DV files to MPEG. Creating a DVD from this is accomplished via the 'Direct burn to DVD' feature.

The TV channel preview quality was very good; in fact, PowerVCR and WinDVR were the only two PVR software that showcased grain-less picture reproduction. Video captures are stored by default in the MPEG format. The quality of the capture was also very good—we didn't see any jerks, nor did we notice any pixelation.

All in all, PowerVCR might well be the best PVR software out there—which is also probably reason for it being bundled with most TV-Tuner cards!

Link: www.cyberlink.com/multi/download/trials_2_ENU.html

WinDVR Version 3

Two years ago, we did a similar comparison. WinDVR finished as the challenger to PowerVCR. Now we're back to our testing desk, looking for something new in WinDVR!